Examiner's Report: PhD in Music (John Ernst Oosthuizen)

Dissertation Title: *The Use of Jazz Style Elements in the Organ Compositions of Surendran Reddy (1962–2010)*
Candidate: John Ernst Oosthuizen
Examiner: PA Schonken, Department of Music
Faculty: Arts and Social Sciences
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I. Overview and Summary

John Ernst Oosthuizen's dissertation, *"Die gebruik van jazz-stylelemente in die orrelkomposisies van Surendran Reddy (1962–2010)"*, presents a sophisticated and theoretically nuanced interrogation of genre hybridity in late 20th- and early 21st-century organ composition. Centred on two seminal works by South African composer Surendran Reddy, *Toccata for Madiba* (1997) and *Mayibuye Suite* (2001), the study articulates a critical response to the limitations of traditional Western analytical frameworks when applied to compositions steeped in jazz idioms.

To remedy this, Oosthuizen constructs a bespoke analytical framework synthesizing elements from Nikolsky's expressive parameters with stylistic taxonomies drawn from both international and South African jazz traditions. The dissertation demonstrates how Reddy's genre-fusing approach (coined "clazz") mobilizes the organ as a politically and aesthetically pluralistic medium, enabling both performer agency and cultural critique.

Methodologically rigorous and conceptually mature, the work situates Reddy's music within broader discourses of post-Apartheid identity, performance practice, and stylistic innovation. It stands as an exemplary contribution to the fields of music analysis, jazz studies, and South African art music, offering an original lens on how the organ can function as a dynamic vehicle for inter-idiomatic synthesis and socio-cultural expression.

II. Original Contributions and Strengths

The dissertation presents a mature and theoretically advanced contribution to the overlapping fields of musicology, performance studies, jazz analysis, and South African cultural discourse. Central to the originality of the study is its re-conceptualization of the analytical apparatus needed to interpret hybrid musical works, and specifically those that resist the stylistic and categorical boundaries of Western art music analysis. By foregrounding the intersection of classical and jazz idioms within organ repertoire, the candidate opens new interpretive terrain not only within South African music scholarship, but also internationally where studies of genre hybridization remain relatively underexplored at the level of organ composition.

The dissertation's most notable strength lies in the development of a tailored analytical framework (Chapter 2) that addresses the insufficiencies of traditional methodologies when faced with works that collapse distinctions between "high art" and vernacular idioms. Drawing from Aleksey Nikolsky's eleven aspects of musical expression and extending them through categorical engagement with both international and indigenous jazz style elements, Oosthuizen creates a structured yet flexible hermeneutic tool that is at once analytically robust and musicologically sensitive.

This framework, in my opinion, is more than adaptive or derivative: it emerges from the ontological demands of the repertoire itself and therefore makes a more substantive

methodological contribution. The distinction drawn between international jazz idioms (Chapter 3) and uniquely South African sub-genres (Chapter 4) provides a culturally grounded typology through which the expressive and structural elements of Reddy's compositions can be meaningfully decoded. Such nuance demonstrates the candidate's keen understanding of stylistic micro-differentiation, a level of granularity too often glossed over in studies of fusion genres.

The application of this framework to Reddy's two principal organ works in Chapters 5 and 6 is exemplary in its analytic depth and clarity. The analysis reveals the syntactical and semiotic functions of jazz-style elements within the compositional fabric. This is most clearly seen in the close reading of the *mbaqanga*- and *marimba*-influenced sections of *Toccata for Madiba*, where the candidate identifies how rhythmic displacements, harmonic substitutions, and modal layering construct meaning that is both politically resonant and aesthetically innovative.

Further, the dissertation contributes to performance studies by framing the organist not as a passive reproducer of notated text but as an active co-creator of meaning. The absence of exhaustive performance instructions in Reddy's organ works is not treated as a lacuna but as an invitation to interpretive freedom, situating the performer within a post-structural paradigm of text-realization. This is theoretically significant, aligning with contemporary performance theory that regards interpretation as a site of cultural inscription and dialogic exchange.

The candidate also demonstrates an impressive command of intertextual discourse. References to historical precursors of genre fusion from Gershwin to Schuller's *third stream* concept are deployed as integral interlocutors in the analytical narrative, which lends the work a historiographical richness and places it firmly within the scholarly tradition of investigating musical syncretism.

Oosthuizen's engagement with Surendran Reddy's philosophy (particularly the notion of "clazz" as a space of aesthetic reconciliation and sociopolitical engagement) adds an additional layer of interpretive depth. The analysis transcends the purely musical to offer insight into the ideological commitments embedded in Reddy's works, especially in their reflection of post-Apartheid aspirations and transnational identity formation.

Therefore, the dissertation's strengths are multifaceted:

- An original analytical framework that respects the ontologies of hybrid music;
- Detailed, informed, and rigorous analysis of stylistic elements in context;
- A sophisticated view of performance as an interpretive and political act;
- An integrated methodology that fuses theory, analysis, and cultural critique;
- A clear contribution to the advancement of South African musicology and the global study of genre fusion.

III. Constructive Critique and Areas for Development

While Oosthuizen's dissertation is commendable in both scope and depth, several areas invite further elaboration or refinement. These are not detracting flaws, but opportunities for continued scholarly maturation and enhanced clarity.

Firstly, the **rhetorical density of the analytical framework**, specifically as presented in Chapter 2 and the extensive appendices, while impressive in its taxonomic ambition, occasionally risks overwhelming the reader. The proliferation of subcategories and stylistic descriptors could benefit from occasional visual consolidation (e.g. tables or hierarchical

schemata) to enhance readability and pedagogical utility. For future publications, a slightly more streamlined presentation of the framework would likely facilitate its uptake by fellow scholars and performers seeking practical analytic tools.

Secondly, the **discussion of improvisation**, a cornerstone of jazz practice, is under-emphasized in the performative readings of Reddy's compositions. While the dissertation effectively analyzes the jazz-style *elements* embedded in notated scores, it engages less with the improvisational ethos that undergirds much of jazz's performative grammar. Given Reddy's own proclivity for extemporization and stylistic fluidity, a more robust engagement with theories of improvisation (Berliner, Monson, or Nettl) could deepen the account of how performer-agency is enacted in real time, especially in interpretive passages lacking prescriptive notation.

A related point concerns the treatment of **organological specificity**. While the dissertation alludes to the organ's evolution (e.g. Hammond instruments, registration practices, and theatre organs), these references could be expanded to more directly address instrumental constraints and affordances...particularly regarding how organ design interacts with jazz idioms. For instance, how do aspects like tremulants, manual configuration, or pedalboard design facilitate or limit the articulation of swing, groove, or polyrhythm? This question is particularly relevant given Reddy's imaginative re-contextualization of the instrument and may warrant more detailed elaboration in any future monograph or journal article.

Additionally, the dissertation's critical discourse could occasionally be **theoretically enriched by engaging more extensively with postcolonial musicological thought**. Although the political dimensions of Reddy's music are acknowledged (especially in relation to *Toccata for Madiba*) a more overt conversation with thinkers such as Kofi Agawu, Veit Erlmann, or Deborah Wong could have fortified the interpretive framing of "clazz" as not only a stylistic synthesis but also a sonic response to cultural hybridity, exile, and memory in post-Apartheid South Africa.

Finally, while the dissertation rightly focuses on Reddy's compositional output, a brief comparative reference to other South African composers experimenting with stylistic synthesis (Abdullah Ibrahim, Paul Hanmer, or Arthur Feder perhaps?) might further contextualize Reddy's position within a broader national or continental aesthetic genealogy.

These observations do not detract from the work's central achievements but point toward rich trajectories for further development and dissemination. The dissertation's foundations are eminently strong; these minor expansions would only serve to enhance its academic and artistic resonance.

IV. Publication Potential

John Oosthuizen's dissertation demonstrates significant scholarly and artistic merit, and several components are eminently suitable for publication in high-impact academic venues. Most notably, the analytical framework for the interpretation of hybrid jazz-classical compositions (specifically as applied to the organ repertoire) constitutes a major theoretical innovation. This framework, if rearticulated with slightly more concise taxonomy and supported by selected case studies from *Toccata for Madiba* and *Mayibuye Suite*, could form the basis for a standalone article in journals such as *Music Theory Online*, *Analytical Approaches to World Music*, or *SAMUS* (South African Music Studies).

Furthermore, the in-depth stylistic analysis of *Toccata for Madiba*, with its intertextual layering of mbaqanga, fugue, and improvisatory elements, could be expanded into a performance-

focused article suitable for journals like *Performance Practice Review*, *Organ Yearbook*, or *Jazz Perspectives*. The interpretation of the organ as a postcolonial instrument, liberated from its Euro-liturgical associations, aligns with current trends in decolonial music scholarship and could invite fruitful interdisciplinary dialogue.

In addition, the appendices containing codified style elements and transcriptions could be adapted into pedagogical resources or analytical models for conservatories or music theory programs focused on genre fusion, post-tonal analysis, or jazz idioms in non-traditional instrumental settings.

The dissertation offers rich potential for serial publication across at least three major axes: (1) analytical method; (2) performance-practice insight; and (3) South African post-Apartheid aesthetics. With minimal editorial revision, these contributions can meaningfully advance both scholarly discourse and practical engagement within and beyond South Africa's academic music community.

V. Final Recommendation

I have carefully examined the doctoral dissertation *"Die gebruik van jazz-stylelemente in die orrelkomposisies van Surendran Reddy (1962–2010)"* submitted by John Ernst Oosthuizen, and I am of the considered opinion that it meets and in certain respects exceeds the scholarly standards required for the conferral of the PhD degree. The dissertation demonstrates exceptional analytical acuity, theoretical innovation, and stylistic maturity in its treatment of genre hybridity, music analysis, and performance practice within a South African context. It offers an original and rigorous analytical framework, supported by detailed application to two of Surendran Reddy's major organ works, while making a significant contribution to the fields of musicology, jazz studies, and cultural discourse.

The candidate exhibits a high level of intellectual independence and theoretical sophistication, and the work is eminently suitable for scholarly publication. **I therefore recommend without reservation that the degree be awarded.** Warmest congratulations to both the candidate and the promotor for an outstanding contribution to music scholarship.

Yours sincerely



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EXTERNAL EXAMINER'S REPORT

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Title: ***Die gebruik van jazz-stylelemente in die orrelkomposisies van Surendran Reddy (1962–2010)***

The candidate has produced an original and highly relevant dissertation in the contemporary field of musicology, performance practice, and South African music studies. It speaks directly to ongoing academic conversations about hybridity, identity, and the permeability of stylistic boundaries in music. The choice of topic—the

integration of jazz idioms into the organ works of Surendran Reddy—constitutes a particularly innovative and necessary contribution to organ scholarship, where the intersection of jazz and classical traditions has long been acknowledged in passing but seldom subjected to systematic analysis. By foregrounding Reddy's oeuvre, the study not only reclaims the significance of a composer whose contribution has been underexplored in scholarly literature but also highlights the pipe organ as an instrument capable of reflecting complex cultural dialogues that extend well beyond the confines of liturgical or European art-music traditions.

The dissertation demonstrates intellectual courage by engaging with the contested terrain of stylistic hybridity. Rather than avoiding the theoretical and methodological difficulties posed by music that resists neat categorisation, the candidate confronts these challenges directly, developing a bespoke analytical framework capable of capturing the nuances of such mixed-idiom compositions. This methodological innovation signals an awareness that conventional analytical tools, designed for tonal Western art music, cannot adequately address the layered rhythmic, harmonic, and textural elements that characterise Reddy's works. It is precisely in this willingness to design new tools, rather than merely apply existing ones, that the study establishes its authority and scholarly originality.

What is most striking is the dissertation's breadth and scope. It moves fluidly between international jazz practices, their specific stylistic conventions, South African idioms such as *kwêla, marabi, mbaqanga*, and *ghoema*, and the distinctive demands of organ performance practice. It situates Reddy's compositions simultaneously within global jazz traditions and a distinctly South African sound world, offering a layered understanding of cultural and musical exchange. The analytical discussion is never pursued in isolation, but consistently tied back to performance practice, ensuring that the research has practical and theoretical implications. Moreover, the dissertation's breadth is not merely a matter of coverage; it reflects the candidate's ability to weave diverse bodies of knowledge into a coherent and persuasive scholarly narrative that models how interdisciplinarity can enrich the study of music and its performance.

Beyond the boundaries of musicology, in my opinion, the significance of this work extends into cultural studies, postcolonial discourse, and debates on identity in post-

apartheid South Africa. By examining Reddy's blending of Western classical idioms with both international jazz and South African township styles, the dissertation demonstrates how music can act as a site of negotiation for cultural memory, hybridity, and reconciliation. It situates the organ—a symbol often associated with European tradition—within a broader, globalised context where instruments and genres construct new forms of cultural identity. In this way, the study resonates with musicians, scholars, and readers concerned with the politics of culture, the legacies of colonialism, and the role of the arts in social transformation. The study provides an invaluable addition to South African organ scholarship by foregrounding the compositions of Surendran Reddy, a composer of exceptional creativity who, until now, has remained on the margins of academic discourse. Whereas much organ research in South Africa has focused on European repertoire and performance traditions, this dissertation shifts the centre of attention to a local figure whose work embodies both artistic innovation and cultural relevance. The candidate recovers Reddy's legacy and situates it within broader scholarly debates about hybridity, stylistic fusion, and cultural representation in music.

By concentrating on two seminal works—*Toccata for Madiba* (1997) and *Mayibuye Suite* (2001)—the dissertation demonstrates how Reddy's distinctive *clazz* style represents a unique synthesis of Western classical idioms, jazz vocabularies, and South African township styles. The analytical treatment of these works convincingly establishes their musicological importance, showing how harmonic language, rhythmic devices, and textural layering operate across multiple stylistic registers. At the same time, the study brings to the fore the aesthetic value of Reddy's music, highlighting the originality of his compositional voice and its political resonance in the years following South Africa's democratic transition. For example, the symbolic dedication of Toccata for Madiba to Nelson Mandela is explored as a commemorative gesture and a musical enactment of reconciliation and cultural dialogue. Similarly, the *Mayibuye Suite* is shown to embody nostalgia, longing, and an affirmation of African identity, thus contributing to broader conversations about belonging and postcolonial expression. In positioning these works as musicologically, aesthetically, and politically significant, the dissertation underscores their multidimensional relevance. They are compositions for performance and cultural artefacts that engage with questions of hybridity, inclusivity, and identity formation. The candidate demonstrates how these

compositions bridge divides—between classical and jazz idioms, between European and African traditions, between sacred and secular contexts—and, in doing so, exemplify the broader sociopolitical processes of post-apartheid South Africa.

Internationally, the study extends its impact by situating the South African organ tradition within global conversations about the blurring of art and popular music. By documenting and critically analysing the incorporation of jazz idioms into organ composition, the dissertation disrupts entrenched assumptions of the organ as a fixed, liturgical, and exclusively European instrument. Instead, it presents the organ as a versatile medium capable of engaging with contemporary idioms and responding to diverse cultural environments. This repositioning of the instrument is not merely a local innovation but contributes to an expanding global discourse in which boundaries between genres are increasingly porous.

The dissertation's contribution also carries critical pedagogical implications. Reddy's works, as analysed here, could serve as exemplary case studies in organ teaching and performance curricula, particularly in courses dealing with interpretation, stylistic analysis, or historically informed performance. By engaging students with compositions that defy singular stylistic categorisation, teachers can encourage them to develop flexible interpretative strategies and to think critically about how cultural contexts shape musical meaning. Incorporating Reddy's *clazz* style into training programmes would also prepare the next generation of organists to navigate a repertoire that is increasingly global, hybrid, and responsive to social realities. Thus, the study enriches scholarship and offers practical avenues for rethinking organ pedagogy in South Africa and beyond.

In this respect, the dissertation makes a timely and significant contribution to the emerging field of organ-and-jazz fusion studies. Providing a detailed case study rooted in South African repertoire ensures that scholarship in this area is not confined to European or American contexts but is broadened to reflect more global perspectives. The study will thus resonate within South Africa and internationally, offering new insights for organists, musicologists, and cultural theorists interested in the intersections of genre, identity, pedagogy, and performance.

The research methodology choices are carefully explained and rigorously applied. The candidate recognised the inadequacy of traditional analytical frameworks (e.g., Schenkerian and Riemannian analysis) for addressing music that integrates jazz idioms. Instead, he constructed a bespoke analytical model based on Aleksey Nikolsky's eleven aspects of musical expression. This is a significant scholarly innovation: the framework respects the integrity of jazz as a recognised music genre. It provides a model that future researchers can adapt to other hybrid repertoires. The qualitative methodology—comprising literature study, score analysis, comparative stylistic catalogues, and the creation of detailed appendices—is implemented with precision. Including South African sub-genres alongside international idioms in the analytical framework gives the study a distinct regional anchoring, ensuring that it does not merely replicate international approaches but develops a truly South African narrative.

The thesis is logically structured and flows smoothly from the broader context (the convergence of classical music and jazz) to the focused analyses of the two selected works. Each chapter builds systematically on the previous, with clear signposting of aims and findings. Awe-inspiring is the level of detail in cataloguing stylistic elements—harmonic, rhythmic, textural, and registrational—which reveals scholarly thoroughness and practical awareness for performers on eclectic pipe organs nationally and abroad. The argumentation is generally strong and coherent. At times, however, the sheer wealth of detail threatens to overwhelm the reader. For example, while the extended catalogues in the appendices are invaluable for reference, their density might distract from the broader narrative flow. Nevertheless, the candidate consistently returns to the central research questions and ties the discussion back to Reddy's two organ works, which prevents the dissertation from losing focus. The use of the Afrikaans language is clear, academic, and largely free of redundancy. The candidate successfully balances scholarly rigour with accessibility, and his writing style demonstrates maturity befitting work at a doctoral level.

Two aspects of originality deserve particular commendation:

1. Analytical framework

By adapting Nikolsky's system and expanding it into a comprehensive jazz-stylistic catalogue (both international and South African), the candidate has provided a tool that future researchers can use well beyond this study.

2. Emphasis on performance practice

The candidate does not treat the scores as static artefacts but views the performer as a co-creative partner in realising Reddy's music. This aligns with contemporary performance-as-research discourses and enriches the study's relevance for practising musicians.

While the dissertation is of very high standard, I offer two constructive suggestions that might have strengthened the research even further:

1. Contextualisation of Audience Reception

Although the study engages deeply with analysis and performance, it could have benefited from a stronger ethnographic or reception-oriented perspective. How have South African or international audiences received Reddy's organ works? From the perspective of performing organists and scholars, this gap is particularly felt. For organists considering programming this repertoire, firsthand accounts of audience reactions—be they surprise, delight, confusion, or a sense of cultural connection—are invaluable data. Understanding reception is not merely anecdotal; it is crucial for assessing a work's viability in the concert hall and its impact beyond academia.

Scholarly discourse would also be enriched by moving beyond textual analysis to include the lived experience of the music. Interviews with organists who have performed these pieces, documenting their interpretative choices and the audience's verbal and non-verbal feedback, or testimonies from listeners, would have added a valuable dimension to understanding their cultural impact. Such evidence would powerfully demonstrate whether the hybridity and cultural dialogue so expertly

analysed on the page truly resonate in practice, completing the cycle from score to performance to public meaning.

2. Comparative Dimension

The candidate might also have positioned Reddy's work alongside other composers experimenting with jazz and organ idioms (e.g., Johannes Matthias Michel and Michel Claus Bantzer). While other composers are mentioned in the literature review, a sustained comparative analysis would have highlighted what is uniquely South African in Reddy's *clazz* style.

Editorial suggestions

1. The abstract is slightly lengthy. It should ideally be condensed to 250–300 words and framed more as a concise summary rather than an introduction.

2. Some chapters (particularly those cataloguing stylistic elements) are incredibly detailed; an executive summary of key findings at the beginning or end of each chapter would improve readability.

3. A glossary in English of South African jazz terms might have assisted international readers unfamiliar with concepts such as *mbaqanga*, *kwêla*, and *ghoema.*

4. Page iv: *Suider-Afrikaanse Kerk- en Konsertorrelistevereniging*

Overall evaluation

This dissertation displays impressive scholarship, originality, and commitment to advancing knowledge in organ studies, jazz research, and South African musicology. It not only honours the memory and creativity of Surendran Reddy but also reframes the pipe organ as a dynamic, global instrument capable of expressing hybrid identities. The candidate demonstrates all the qualities expected at the doctoral level: independence of thought, research methodological innovation, comprehensive command of literature, and significant contribution to knowledge. Despite minor areas for improvement, the dissertation is a work of high academic calibre and worthy of the award of a PhD.

I award the dissertation a well-deserved **PASS**.

Sincerely,



Prof T.J. van Wyk

September 2025
